Chapter Seven

To the Rubicon (And Beyond)

> ‘I never thought I’d live to see the day when I would want to go to war.’ [1]
>
> (General Earle Wheeler, US army chief of staff)

> ‘We’re gonna blast them now! We will die, but we will sink them all – we will not become the shame of the fleet.’[2]
>
> (Captain Valentin Savitsky)

> ‘It is necessary now … to choose between two admittedly regrettable – but nevertheless distinguishable post-war environments – one where we lose twenty million people, and the other where we lose a hundred and fifty million people.’[3]
>
> (General Buck Turgidson)

In early January 49 BCE Julius Caesar led his Thirteenth Legion across the River Rubicon and marched on Rome. Under Roman law, bringing his troops into Italy represented insurrection and treason. Once he crossed the Rubicon, he passed the point of no return. ‘The die is cast,’ he observed.

If nuclear weapons had been used in 1962, would humanity have passed the point of no return? Was escalation to Armageddon (and beyond) inevitable? Nikita Khrushchev seemed to think so: ‘if indeed war should break out, then it would not be in our power to stop it, for such is the logic